

THE EVOLUTION OF HUMAN CONSCIOUSNESS AND THE ILLUSION OF SELF:
A HEURISTIC EXPLORATION

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Content	Page
TITLE PAGE.....	i
COPYRIGHT PAGE.....	ii
SIGNATURE APPROVAL PAGE.....	iii
ACKNOWLEDGMENTS.....	iv
TABLE OF CONTENTS.....	v
ABSTRACT.....	vii
CHAPTER	
1 PROBLEM FORMULATION	
THE PHENOMENON OF THE SELF.....	1
Introduction.....	1
Definitions.....	2
Background of the Study.....	6
Statement of the Problem.....	7
Hypothesis/Research Questions.....	9
Purpose of the Study.....	10
Limitations of the Study.....	10
CHAPTER	
2 REVIEW OF THE LITERATURE.....	12
Consciousness History	
Pre-Conscious Mentality.....	12
The Beginnings of Language.....	13
Bicameral Origins.....	14
The Evolutionary Advantage of Self in Relation.....	16
Ego as Mediator.....	19
Consciousness Psychology	
Ego Development.....	20
Hallucinatory Qualities.....	21
Identification and Neurosis.....	22
The Illusion of Self	
Psychological.....	24
Scientific.....	25
CHAPTER	
3 RESEARCH METHODS.....	29

	Research Approach.....	29
	Research Design.....	32
	Research Subjects.....	32
	Instrumentation and Data Collection.....	32
CHAPTER		
4	RESULTS.....	33
	Summary.....	33
	Hypothesis/ Research Questions.....	33
	Results.....	33
CHAPTER		
5	SUMMARY, DISCUSSION, AND RECOMMENDATIONS.....	41
	Summary.....	41
	Discussion.....	43
	Recommendations.....	45
	REFERENCES.....	48

Abstract of Thesis Presented to
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**The Evolution of Human Consciousness and the Illusion of Self:
A Heuristic Exploration**

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This thesis paper explores the evolution of consciousness and the subsequent phenomenon of the sense of self as a subjectively perceived, internal, willful, independently existing being. The researcher proposes that this apparent center of intentional conscious awareness is an illusion.

As preliminary groundwork for the study, human psychological development is explored and defined within the hierarchical context of perception, cognition, consciousness, ego development, and subsequent identification with “I” as knower/thinker/feeler/doer. Literature within the fields of psychology, spirituality, philosophy, anthropology, and neuroscience is reviewed to compare the historical framework of human mentality with modern psychological development. Cultural and social adaptations are seen to support the development of ego mentality and the necessity of mediated, relational duality in the modern world. With support from the literature, the

recognition of compulsory psychological functioning is teased apart from the sense of self, which then loses its grounding as an actual, concrete facet of experience.

To personally explore the appearance of the self, the study is undertaken through a heuristic investigation and divided into phenomenological and ontological methods. The meditative practices of mindfulness, self-inquiry, and bare attention are employed to experience and investigate consciousness and the subjective arising of selfhood. Through direct experience, concepts are seen to lack solidity, and paradoxical territory is encountered. The relative interpretations and implications are reviewed and evaluated amidst the laying bare of what *is*.

CHAPTER 1

PROBLEM FORMATION

THE PHENOMENON OF THE SELF

Introduction

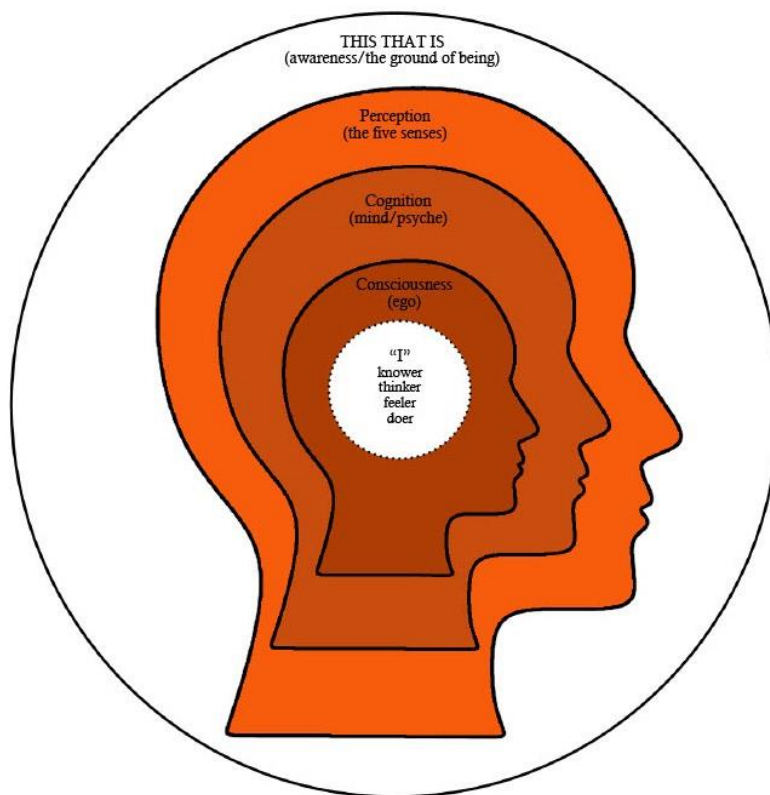
The sense of being a separate self, inhabiting a body and looking out through the eyes is a basic feature of modern human existence (Ralston, 2010). We credit this “I” with perceiving, thinking, feeling, making decisions, and choosing how to interact with the world. It appears to be “I” who runs the show of my own life and enjoys the fruits of my labor. However, the demands and expectations of this “I” also cause a great deal of suffering and anxiety, with the fear that it will not get what it wants if it does not remain in control. It appears to always need more of something and is perpetually in search of a better experience to be had.

What exactly is this sense of self? Is it who or what we *actually* are, and more so, is it even necessary? Spiritual masters have been exploring this question for ages (Godman, 1985; Ralston, 2010; Wilhelm, 1962; Wu Wei, 2004b) and it has more recently sparked the interest of philosophers, psychologists, and neuroscientists (Azarian, 2023, Damasio, 2010; Edinger, 1972; Engler, 2002; Harris, 2012; Jaynes, 1976; Tollifson, 2017). This research paper will explore an array of literature in various fields in attempts to determine how and why the sense of self arises within the evolutionary context of consciousness awareness, and ultimately expose its illusory nature. In order to do so, the self must also be personally investigated, as its nature is a wholly subjective experience. A heuristic study based in a multifaceted meditative approach to looking at the self will be undertaken and examined, ideally encouraging readers to do the same.

Definitions

Before moving forward, it is absolutely vital to define how certain words will be used within the context of this research paper. The necessary terms to define are perception, cognition, consciousness, ego, and awareness. I will be particularly focused on consciousness and awareness, as these terms are often used interchangeably in modern language but will refer to very distinct “things” within this paper. Clarifying these words will greatly aid the reader in setting a context for this research. Expounded detail will be provided within the literature review. For the sake of even further clarification on usage within this thesis, I have created a diagram which displays the relationship within and between these concepts. I will reference Figure 1 throughout this section.

Figure 1



I begin with perception, which is the ability to sense and respond to a stimulus (Jaynes, 1976, p. 448). For humans, this relates to the five senses of tasting, touching, smelling, seeing, and hearing. Cognition involves the base mental functioning of thought, the addition of which allows us to integrate and interpret our senses (Michel, 2020). Cognition can be viewed as the mind, which includes beliefs, desires, and motivations, the content of which is informed by perception.

Just as perception informs cognition, cognition informs consciousness. In Figure 1 (strictly for elucidating meaning), you will see that each “capacity” is contained within the other like layers of an onion. Consciousness arises *within* the framework of cognition and perception. As psychologist Julian Jaynes points out, “there is no operation in consciousness that did not occur in behavior first” (1976, p. 449). Consciousness is a cognitive feedback loop of sorts, as it is the ability to simulate the perceptual/cognitive system within itself. “Being conscious is the ability to have subjective experiences, wishes, desires, and complex thoughts, and to perform flexible, self-initiated, purposeful behaviors” (Schooler, 2012, p. 57). The key phrase here is self-initiated. Consciousness can only occur *in relation*, which brings us to the task of defining the ego.

Psychiatrist Carl Jung (1973) was adamant in pointing out that “nothing can be conscious without an ego to which it refers.” Consciousness implies a differentiation into subject and object. Therefore, without a reference point, there cannot be a relation to some-*thing*. The ego acts as that reference point and can be viewed as the “seat of consciousness;” the center which we regard as “I” (Edinger, 1972, p. 156). Ego refers to a conceptual representation of the self; who a person thinks they are and the way in which they organize their experience (Wilbur, 1993). The function of ego is to meditate between

instincts and social morals; to create relation, and therefore subjectivity. If the entirety of mind or psyche exists as cognition, but remains unconscious as such, consciousness is the ego's relation to those contents (Edinger, 1984, p. 36). It is that which allows content to be known and related to.

In this sense, Julian Jaynes (1976) asserts that consciousness is analogous to self-consciousness or ego-consciousness — symbols in relation to a “me.” According to Jaynes (1976), who cites philosophers Descartes, Locke, and Hume, consciousness, in the denotative sense, is what is introspectable. In the connotative sense, he defines it as an analog “I,” narrating in a functional mind-space (p. 450). Jaynes (1976) points to consciousness as a mentally generated metaphor for reality itself. Ego is the metaphorical notion of the external body self which moves within and relates to that reality. Within this view, self-consciousness is a mental replica of the external world in order to “know” it. Our identification with this “knowing” is what constitutes our sense of self. The complexity of this identification is what will be explored within further sections of this paper.

In referring back to Figure 1, the descriptions inform the layers of colored “headspaces,” all of which occur within human brain functioning (Williams, 2011). The next, more ambitious task is to define what these mental systems occur within, or *as*. I will approach this by looking at consciousness from another angle, according to spiritual speaker and author, Joan Tollifson (2017):

Consciousness is the dividing up of unicity into apparent multiplicity, the dream-like creation of apparently substantial forms out of what is actually formless energy. Consciousness is the world of duality and apparent separation, including

most basically the thought-sense of subject and object, self and not-self – it draws boundary lines, tells stories – it is the movie of waking life.

Psychiatrist and Jungian analyst, Edward Edinger, echoes Tollifson, stating that consciousness arises within something. Tollifson (2017) calls it “formless energy” while Edinger (1984) calls it “living awareness.” Edinger also refers to Meister Eckhart who is quoted as saying, “we know by being known” (p. 54). Indian guru Nisargadatta Maharaj (1973) defined consciousness as the “I am” and awareness as “that by which I know I am.” Consciousness appears within awareness. Consciousness is two and awareness is one. Maharaj goes on to say:

Awareness is primordial; it is the original state, beginning-less, endless, uncaused, unsupported, without parts, without change. Consciousness is on contact, a reflection against a surface, a state of duality. There can be no consciousness without awareness, but there can be awareness without consciousness, as in deep sleep. Awareness is absolute, consciousness is relative to its content; consciousness is always of something (p. 29).

Referring back to Tollifson (2017), “Awareness is nondual – no inside or outside, no beginning or end, wholeness, the ever-present here and now (that which is conscious of being conscious) consciousness gets mesmerized by its own creations, but awareness just is.” If all things occur within a formless *this*, awareness cannot be conceived of as a “thing” itself. Therefore, calling it anything at all is very deceiving since our language can only point to something objective. As consciousness teacher Peter Ralston (2010) states, “the very nature of consciousness and being is Nothing;” or no-thing (p. 750). He further describes it as “unknown-being,” which is ultimately the very nature of all that is.

That said, for the sake of discussion and comprehension within this paper, we shall call it awareness, or the ground of being.

To briefly summarize the intersection of the crucial concepts here, let us once again refer back to Figure 1. This-that-is (awareness) is that which contains all, as denoted by the unbroken circle. Within this circle we reference human perception (the five senses), which informs cognition (mind/psyche). Perception and cognition inform consciousness, or the ability to mentally represent the world in relation to a subject (ego). Within this diagram, the more internal the space is, the more evolved the capacity (which will be discussed at length within the literature review). At the very center we reach the “I” – the sense that we are the knower, thinker, feeler, doer, and controller of our own experience. Here we have a small, constricted circle, yet its containment is a broken line. It lacks color, similarly to the background of awareness itself. This visual symbology points to the questions of what this “I” is made of and whether or not it actually exists as some-thing. These are the pointed questions that I will be investigating within this study.

Background of the Study

As illustrated earlier in defining consciousness for the purposes of this paper, psychiatrist Carl Jung could not imagine consciousness without a subject. He believed that one can only liberate oneself from the opposites to a certain extent, or risk unconsciousness, which would be comparable to psychological death. He saw “transcendence” as dangerous in that without subjectivity, one would identify with and basically become all of the unconscious material within the psyche (Peter, 2009, p. 45). This is ultimately speaking toward a disidentification with ego as the reference point within psychic content. His theory is supported by many modern-day studies into the

nature of ego-loss, within psychological disorders such as schizophrenia, as well as psychedelic drug-induced experiences (Mitterauer, 2001; Carhartt-Harris et al. 2016). These states are defined by a loss of boundaries and can be interpreted as positive (inflation) or negative (dissociation); however, as Jung pointed out, they ultimately pose significant challenges to normal human functioning. They are perhaps experiences of interest, but with the risk of depersonalization and a detachment from one's own body, thoughts, and organic way of being (Deane et al. 2020).

On the other hand, many spiritual practitioners have described a similar loss of self as the peak of human evolution (Godman, 1985; Maharaj, 1973; Maurice, 1901; Wu Wei, 2004b). This boundless, stateless state has been called enlightenment, self-realization, non-dual awareness, and various forms of mystical union, said to bring peace, equanimity, and an end to suffering. Discerning the differences between these highly varied degrees of appraisal requires personally questioning and examining the very nature of this sense of self.

Statement of the Problem

In order to examine the self, it is necessary to see if it is possible to tease apart ego functioning, as a psychological complex, and "I" identification, as a specific construct. In other words, what, if any, is the difference between self-concept and self-identification? Both are quite ethereal when objectified, as they are based in mentality and thus lack real solidity but are very much central to our experiencing. Consciousness educator, Peter Ralston (2010) describes it as, "What we don't notice is how much of our very sense and perception of ourselves is a product of mind, even though it appears to be an observation or direct experience of what's there" (p. 264). For some humans this lack

of solidity subtly brings about an underlying feeling of ungroundedness, as a conceptual self has displaced our actual, real sense of being. Must the conceptual self be done away with in order to know what we really are?

The belief that this conceptual self should be eliminated is a prime cause of what psychotherapist John Welwood (2002) deemed to be spiritual bypassing – using spiritual ideals to avoid facing unresolved psychological/emotional issues. Clinical psychologist and Buddhist scholar, Jack Engler (2003), explains:

The Buddhist teaching that one has no enduring self ('emptiness,' 'no-self') is open to a fateful misinterpretation in our western context, namely, that I do not need to struggle to find out who I am, what my desires and aspirations are, what my needs are, what my capabilities and responsibilities are, how I am relating to others, and what I could or should do with my life. The no-self doctrine seems to relieve me of the burden of these tasks and to justify their premature abandonment: if I am (spiritually) nobody, then I don't need to become (psychologically) somebody (p. 36-37).

Ontological emptiness is mistakenly confused with psychological emptiness. The ego appears to have significant necessity, as it is the function that guides our personal needs and acknowledges our own capacities and relational abilities. Psychotherapist Mark Epstein (2013) elucidates, "It is not the ego, in the Freudian sense, that is the actual target of the Buddhist insight, it is rather, the self-concept, the 'representational' component of the ego, the actual internal experience of one's self that is targeted" (p. 107-108). Thus, it seems that the ego does not need to be eliminated or transcended, but perhaps the representational self can be seen as lacking concrete existence. In that way, it

would not be about getting rid of something, but seeing the groundlessness for what it *already is*.

When it is not seen for what it is, our abstract solidification of that apparent groundlessness and the identification with our subjectivity appears to be that which causes us much suffering (Edinger, 2018). Taoist philosopher Wei Wu Wei (2004) put it this way:

This which pretends to choose and to act as a separate individual-being is subject in identification with its object, limited by objectivity. This is the dualism of pseudo-subject/object, and is the cause of all suffering that exists, or has ever existed in the apparent universe (p. 44).

Viewing what we actually *are* as an objective entity appears to be at the very root of the problem to be studied.

Hypothesis/Research Questions

The central hypothesis of this research is that the phenomenon of the subjective, separate “self,” which appears to be at the center of consciousness awareness, is an illusion. Illusions are subjective experiences that are not what they seem. The American Psychological Association defines an illusion as, “a false sensory percept; a distortion in memory; any false belief or mistaken idea.” Illusions are generated by the brain and are experiences of the mind rather than in external reality. Questions that stem from the proposed self-illusion are: Does the sense of self have any objective existence? What is it comprised of and how does it come to arise? Is it essential for our survival? Most essentially, how can the self be directly investigated if it is the very sense of identity that

is conducting the investigation? If it is in fact an illusion, what are the implications of its existence as such?

Purpose of the Study

Consciousness researcher Julian Jaynes (1976) called for a “paleontology of consciousness” in order to discern how this world of subjectivity was formed (p. 216). I intend to do this within my study by means of exploring the sense of self and how it arises within the context of perception, cognition, and ego-consciousness. The arising of an internal sense of “I” as the doer/thinker/feeler/knower will be investigated within a historical context as well as a developmental psychological context in the literature review. Modern findings in neuroscience will also be reviewed. This information will be used to support my personal heuristic study within the actual subjective experiential field of consciousness and self-identification.

The objective within the study is to use various forms of meditation practice and inquiry to explore the arising of the senses as well as the process of thinking and how it relates to a sense of self. Can an independently existing “I” actually be found in direct experience?

Limitations of the Study

A study within the realm of consciousness will always have the inherent limitation of being subjective, therefore involving personal bias. Psychologist Bruce Hood describes how it is a “dualistic problem if we think we can objectively examine our own minds independently, because our mind and self are both generated by the brain” (Harris, 2012). Philosopher Gilbert Ryle similarly pointed out that one cannot be both the hunter and the

hunted (Harris, 2012). Thus, any-*thing* within consciousness which can be reported on, evaluated, or conceptualized is objective. The subjectivity of a “knower” cannot be approached in any way, just as an eye cannot see itself. This intrinsic predicament will be discussed at length within the study analysis.

There is also the limitation of this study being conducted through the perspective of one participant. Others who investigate the self through meditation might very well have substantially different experiences. I intend to do my best to relate my own insight to the respected insights of former spiritual practitioners, educators, and psychologists.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF THE LITERATURE

Consciousness History: Pre-Conscious Mentality

What was human mentality like before consciousness or the ability to self-reflect? Philosopher and scholar Levi-Bruhl defined “participation mystique” as the hallmark of primitive mentality. This implies the nondifferentiation between subject and object (Wilhelm, 1962, p. 123). One can experience, but without the capacity to reflect on that experience; it cannot be “known” in the modern sense that we are familiar with. Jungian analyst Edward Edinger (1972) phrased it as, “pain and suffering and death do exist prior to the birth of consciousness, but if there is no consciousness to experience them, they do not exist psychologically” (p. 25). This coincides with Julian Jaynes’ (1976) argument that perception and even cognition can happen on a nonconscious level (p. 448). We can sense a stimulus and respond appropriately without reflection. Such is the case with many modern activities, such as driving a car or taking part in anything that one is highly accustomed to. The body functions and the brain makes decisions accordingly, without distinct consciousness of doing so.

Anthropologist Brian McVeigh (2018) supports Jaynes’ claim, saying that, “We can be awake, alert, and attentive without experiencing the world in an interiorized, self-aware manner. Self-conscious subjectivity as we experience it is a neurocultural adaptive add-on” (p. 33). If so, how and why did this neurocultural adaptive add-on come to be?

Consciousness History: The Beginnings of Language

The evolutionary step into the development of verbal language appears to play a significant role in the movement toward a conscious mentality. As humans developed the ability to create symbols to represent external objects (and eventually states of being), this automatically generated the first form of objective relation, which is a hallmark of consciousness (Jaynes, 1976). “Consciousness is based on the process of a dialectic... dialectic means speaking across, between two things. It requires a twoness to take place” (Edinger, 2018, p. 23). An intriguing illustration of the lack of this “twoness” is blind and deaf American author Helen Keller’s experience prior to learning language, which she describes in her 1908 book, *The World I Live In*:

Before my teacher came to me, I did not know that I am. I lived in a world that was a no-world. I cannot hope to describe adequately that unconscious, yet conscious time of nothingness. I did not know that I knew aught, or that I lived or acted or desired (Ross-Callahan, 2015).

Without language and the capacity to symbolize relation, Helen Keller was perceiving and cognizing, yet unconscious in terms of experiencing her experience. Spiritual teacher John Wheeler (2010) supports Helen Keller’s observation in saying that, “Without the arising of the relative sense of being conscious, which is largely dependent on the presence of the body as a matrix or vehicle for consciousness to manifest, you do not know that you are.” Verbal language manifests within the human brain and gives rise to the beginning of knowable experience.

Consciousness History: Bicameral Origins

Julian Jaynes' theory regarding the bicameral mind is a compelling way to bridge the evolutionary gap between the unconscious state of "participation mystique" and the beginnings of consciousness as language evolved. While his theory has much complexity, nuance, and supporting evidence, I will only provide a relatively concise overview for the purposes of this paper. Jaynes (1976) asserts that before the development of consciousness (thoughts in relation to an "I"), humans experienced thoughts as auditory hallucinations, interpreted as the voices of authority. These authoritative commands were originally attributed to chiefs and social superiors, eventually being viewed as directives from the gods when the superiors died but the commands continued to be heard.

It is important to recognize that minds can be shaped by culture but lack metacognitive (reflective thinking) access to thoughts about personal internalized narrating. This is why bicameral mind is viewed as on the precipice of conscious mentality. It is relational, literally meaning "of two minds," with a directive and a followed action. However, there is not yet any conception of personal volition in relation to an individual. Researcher Gary Williams (2011) states, "Bicameral mind is phenomenally-conscious but not access-conscious. The bicameral human is an animal who perceives the world, but whose mental content is not accessible for conscious access, voluntary control, or rational articulation" (p. 10). These humans were fully functional, yet believed to have been unable to introspect or reason. Cognitive social psychologist John Kihlstrom echoes this non-reflective capability: "Many perceptual and cognitive operations can occur without individuals being conscious" (Schooler, 2012, p. 67). Thus, based on Jaynes' (1976) theory, despite being fully functional societies, it was highly

likely that ancient peoples lacked self-consciousness in terms of claiming personal volition, and instinctively attributed all action and behavior to external, superior voices.

To address the interpretation of those voices (thoughts) as rulers or gods, it is useful to look toward Jungian theory on psychological archetypes. Archetypes are viewed as mentally expressed instincts, or innate patterns of behavior (Edinger, 2018, p. 28). According to Jaynes (1976), as human groups grew larger and evolved into societies, social obedience was essential in order to control instinctive animal behavior. Obedience to leaders' directives was eventually internalized as thought, but perceived as auditory, commanding voices. When leaders died, members of the group continued to hear those voices, and thus began attributing them to the existence of metaphysical beings. Jungian analyst Edward Edinger (1984) also agrees that the objective psyche was first experienced and described in a metaphysical context. He points out that archetypes were viewed as supernatural entities before being seen as psychic realities. All volition was projected onto these "gods" of the mind (p. 79). Theologian Richard Wilhelm (1962) supports this claim as well:

Many of the earlier gods have evolved out of 'persons' into personified ideas, and finally into abstract ideas, for activated unconscious contents always appear first as projections upon the outside world. In the course of mental development, consciousness gradually assimilates them as projections in space and reshapes them into conscious ideas which then forfeit their original autonomous and personal character (p.110).

Before conscious mentality, these archetypes were all-consuming because they were not perceived in relation. Edward Edinger (2018) speaks to this lack of reflectivity,

saying that, “unconscious contents, not yet subjectively realized, are like the demons/gods of primitive man” (p. 43). As societies expanded and larger systems of language developed, more and more of the external world was objectified into symbols out of relational necessity. Bicameral mind began to break down amidst the warring of neighboring civilizations. This could be viewed as a clash of the gods, as thoughts delegating social control were completely different in varied groups (Jaynes, 1976). With too many competing “voices”, control gave way to chaos. Richard Wilhelm (1962) summarizes this outlook, saying:

Higher and wider consciousness, which comes about only through assimilation of the unfamiliar, tends towards autonomy, towards revolution against the old gods who are nothing other than those powerful, unconscious, archetypal images which have always held consciousness in thrall (p. 88).

At some point the god-volitional mentality was no longer a psychologically adaptive way to structure and control impulsive behavior. External disorder initiated the organizing principles of the psyche to begin to be restructured by a new type of mentality. This leads us to the development of ego consciousness.

Consciousness History: The Evolutionary Advantage of Self in Relation

In referring back to Helen Keller’s experience, she states, “when I learned the meaning of ‘I’ and ‘me’ and found that I was something, I began to think. Then consciousness first existed for me” (Ross-Callahan, 2015). Learning language opened up her world, and learning a self-concept gave her a sense of identity. Psychiatrist Richard Maurice Bucke (1901) reiterates that consciousness is only possible with the formation of

conceptual language. The more concepts added, the more complexity, such as with the self. He explained, “When an organism which possesses simple consciousness only, attains to self-consciousness, it becomes aware for the first time that it is a separate creature, or self existing in a world which is apart from it” (p. 63). Self and other, subject and object, become the dual nature of relating to the world. Edward Edinger (1984) agrees with this, in that consciousness “is produced by the experience of the opposites suffered” (p. 32). If there is no position to “see” psychic contents from, then it does not exist in the proper sense. Edinger (1984) says:

Nobody seems to have noticed that without a reflecting psyche the world might as well not exist, and that, in consequence, consciousness is a second world-creator, and also that the cosmogenic myths do not describe the absolute beginning of the world but rather the dawning of consciousness as the second creation (p. 89).

Neuroscientist Antonio Damasio (2010) agrees, saying, “When selves do not occur within minds, those minds are not conscious in the proper sense” (p. 8). He goes on to say that “Mind is a most natural result of evolution, and it is largely nonconscious, internal, and unrevealed. It comes to be known thanks to the narrow window of consciousness” (p. 177). The “broker” of experience is the self.

The relative position is created by means of metaphorical language that is imposed upon the world, and it is that which creates the “knowing” of objective existence. Consciousness scholar, Brian McVeigh (2022) thus claims that consciousness is transmitted culturally and is not innate or genetic. The psyche cannot look at its contents without a mirror, and the metaphor of the self is the mirror. Metaphor is the map for the territory (Jaynes, 1976).

Thus, the conceptual, navigational self is generated mentally to reflect the external body that exists in the world, just as all five senses are also recreated in thought. We relate to the world through our senses so our mental constructions that give rise to meaning often use the senses as metaphors (Jaynes, 1976). The “I” which surveys the interior world of mind is a metaphor for the “eye” which surveys the physical world. Subjective consciousness thus points to an operational space in which “I” can narrate out alternative actions and their consequences (Jaynes, 1976).

With a conceptual self, one is able to mentally plan, organize, and project outcomes, which clearly has many evolutionary benefits for a human. Jaynes (1976) gives the example of a human being able to craft an alternate plan of action during an attack, and perhaps strategize to hide rather than instinctually fight and be killed. On a base level, the ability to imagine oneself in various scenarios allows one to choose a course of action that might increase one’s survival chances. Dualistic mentality is fundamentally a survival mechanism, similar to the claws and fangs that animals evolved in order to protect themselves (Prendergast, 2002, p. 139). Research in cognitive science shows us that adaptive strategies to predict the behavior of others is based on a strong representation of self and has significant social and evolutionary relevance (Halligan et al., 2017). Zen practitioner and author, Alex Tzelnic (2021), states:

The concept of self has allowed the human species to flourish to an extent that is unrivaled in the history of life on this planet. By ruminating on the past and strategizing for the future, countless generations of selves have been able to orchestrate growth on a scale and magnitude that has dramatic implications for all life.

Perceptive abilities have evolved to serve survival, as we must know how things relate to us so that we can respond appropriately (Ralston, 2020, p. 454). The adaptive mental upgrade of consciousness allows us to conceptually rehearse scenarios and perform goal-directed action to suit more and more complex external circumstances (McVeigh, 2022, p. 36). In earlier humans, this upgrade essentially evolved as a physical survival advantage. In modern times, within the Western world, where being hunted or attacked is not a constant threat, social survival has now taken precedence.

Consciousness History: Ego as Mediator

Within modern Western psychology, we view the ego as the mediator between instinct and social morals (Damasio, 2010). If there were no societal rules imposed upon our instinct, there would be no need for an ego. We become self-conscious by reflecting on our own thoughts, behavior, and actions, in relation to others. Our interiorized world of self-other relations through socialization generates reflection and reconsideration (McVeigh, 2022, p. 48). As Jaynes (1976) said, we are constantly considering other possibilities in order to keep us from acting too impulsive and rash. The metaphorical “I” is always under the influence of many collective cognitive imperatives (p. 402).

In this sense, we become more conscious when we experience conflict, because new behavioral/social solutions must be arrived at (Edinger, 1984, p. 18). The ego references memory from similar previous events and creates new metaphorical analogies that can be applied to the external world. In early humans (and in primates in general) it is clear that the presence of a dominant individual activated certain behaviors. Likewise, today, the presence of a (perceived to be) dominant individual activates psychological stress; consciousness and awareness of self for appropriate social decision-making

(Jaynes, 1976). Self-consciousness is activated by varying levels of anxiety. How does this relate to the development of our modern mentality?

Consciousness Psychology: Ego Development

Conscious mentality has become very much engrained in Western culture. We can look at the basic psychological theory of object relations in childhood to see that children internalize and identify with attributes of their parents and the ways in which their parents relate to them. This is how children begin to construct their sense of self in relation to the world (Welwood, 2002, p. 40). “Consciousness becomes embedded in language and so is learned easily by children” (Jaynes, p. 449). As a child learns language and begins to internalize parental voices, this assists them in the ability to reflect on and control their actions. Psychiatric researcher Alfonso Russo (2019) says, “With the help of private speech, young children are able to distance themselves from the immediate environment and let their own internal plans drive their behavior and attention” (p. 59).

Recognizing oneself as “separate” provides a sense of control for the developing child. A solid ego structure allows the child to “function effectively in the world without being debilitated by inner conflict” (Welwood, 2002, p. 38). As mediator between instincts and social morals (as deemed by parents and authority figures), one has the ability to choose the appropriate course of action. Cognitive researchers have pointed out that a disturbance to the development of the internally represented self can result in abnormal subjective experiences such as depersonalization or a distortion of boundaries between self-other/self-world, as in schizophrenia (Halligan, et al., 2017). Many psychological disorders stem from distorted ego development in childhood. It is clear that this psychological structure is vital for navigating our modern world.

We can directly compare this presently conventional human developmental configuration with the ancient bicameral mentality, as purported by Julian Jaynes (1976). Humans with a so-called bicameral mind functioned through an external locus of control (“gods”), while modern humans have evolved into a seemingly more efficient mentality with an internal locus of control (“ego”). It is clear that both behavioral “control centers” arise out of complex social requirements, however, are they both truly opposing “inner” and “outer” perceptions in actuality?

Consciousness Psychology: Hallucinatory Qualities

“Consciousness, understood as the ability to ‘see’ things that do not exist and conjure up non-existent, imaginary scenarios, is semi-hallucinatory in nature and is therefore an evolutionary descendant of hallucination” (McVeigh, 2018, p. 10–11). Whether one attributes their decisions to externalized gods or to an internalized personal ego, both are thought-based conceptions that influence our behavior but cannot be pointed to in physical reality. Consciousness scholar Brian McVeigh (2018) supports this, explaining that because of complex socio-political patterns, hallucinated divine authorization was replaced with hallucinated self-authorization for more effective decision-making (p. 32). Donald Hebb (1969) agrees, saying, “I propose that introspection is an illusion so strongly established that it amounts to hallucination” (p. 55). The crux here is that our modern system of decision-making still appears to be a hallucination, despite its perceived sanity, according to modern society.

Consciousness teacher Peter Ralston (2010) points out that, “As humankind developed the ability to conceptualize (to fabricate or represent things that aren’t actually present) we started down a path this is both powerful and slippery. Once a concept can be

created to represent something real, it can be used to replace what is real” (p. 294). This leads us deeper into the heart of the matter that I have set out to address. We have seen that ego development and reflective consciousness is important for proper functioning in our modern Western world. However, we have come to identify with this psychological complex and view it as who we in fact are. What are the implications?

Consciousness Psychology: Identification and Neurosis

Albert Einstein painted a perfectly descriptive picture, saying, “If the moon, in the act of completing its eternal way around the earth, were gifted with self-consciousness, it would feel thoroughly convinced that it was traveling its way of its own accord on the strength of a resolution taken once and for all” (Robinson, 1995, p.172). We humans have been gifted with self-consciousness and do exactly that. The modern ego is conditioned to take responsibility for the actions, thoughts, and behaviors that align with its best intentions. However, the push and pull between instincts and morals is always at hand, appearing situationally in constantly varied ways, and our best intentions are often unmet. The more deliberate individuals view this state of psychic conflict as their private responsibility to properly handle. These stressors of decision-making lead to states of chronic neurosis (Edinger, 2018).

In commenting on the neurosis of modern consciousness, Julian Jaynes (1976), made an important point, explaining that there is no biological mechanism for turning off the body’s physical response to continued thoughts that the “I” identification generates. Fear becomes anxiety, shame becomes guilt, pain becomes suffering, all because it is perceived in relation to an internal self that is singularly responsible (p. 461–462). Self-doubt emerges with hyper-subjectivity and we find ourselves in a great deal of

psychological torment, bearing the weight and repercussions of all decisions (McVeigh, 2022, p. 53)

According to Jungian analyst Edward Edinger (1972), this burden of consciousness would appear to be one-sided from a psychological developmental standpoint. While an individual must develop conscious relationality from an individualized perspective, he asserts that it is imperative for one to see that the ego viewpoint is not the whole of the picture (p. 6). “As I see it, the psyche is a world in which the ego is contained. Perhaps there are also fishes who believe that they contain the sea” (Wilhelm, 1962, p.130). The ego, as the seat of consciousness, believes itself to be the volitional axel of all knowing. Whereas the whole of the psyche is a world of its own that functions autonomously, and many inner and outer experiences overwhelm or contradict the ego (Edinger, 2018, p. 20). Psychic contents do not belong to the ego, as the ego, in actuality, is but one piece of a highly complex psychological system (Hopkins, 2008, p. 170). Consciousness, as such, does not “know” all mentality. Julian Jaynes (1976) fittingly explains:

Consciousness is a much smaller part of our mental life than we are conscious of, because we cannot be conscious of what we are not conscious of. How simple that is to say; how difficult to appreciate! It is like asking a flashlight in a dark room to search around for something that does not have any light shining upon it. The flashlight, since there is light in whatever direction it turns, would have to conclude that there is light everywhere. And so consciousness can seem to pervade all mentality when actually it does not (p. 23).

Consciousness, from its own perspective, appears to be all-encompassing, when it is but an epiphenomenal offshoot of cognition and language. We box and label this one particular function as “I” and come to view it as the thinker, the doer, the feeler, and the perceiver, the very center of individual existence. While this function clearly has its usefulness, is it really a “self” in its own right? Is it really traversing the earth of its own accord, or is it just as absurd as Einstein’s imaginative description of the “self-consciousness moon” revolving around the earth purely because of its own personal willpower?

The Illusion of Self: Psychological

“Being able to ‘see’ the sky while we’re inside the cave might have been confusing for the minds of early man if they couldn’t make a distinction between concept and reality, but perhaps no less confusing than supposing a mental activity is somehow a self” (Ralston, 2010, p. 345). Perhaps initially confusing to earlier humans, viewing this seemingly volitional mental activity as oneself is now the most conventional conceptual belief of modern western humans.

Director of the Julian Jaynes Society, Marcel Kuijsten (2019), re-emphasizes Jaynes’s observation that the illusion of subjectivity is created by the learned ability to narratize. When this capability is not present, the “self-process” is suspended, such as in dreamless sleep, anesthesia, or in brain disease. Thus, how can that be what we innately are? “Without the ‘creation’ of self, there is no self to be perceived. Once self is created and identified, however, it becomes the central aspect of our awareness, and we fail to notice that it is in fact not an experience of being” (Ralston, 2010, p. 271). The interesting takeaway here is that self appears to be perceived as content, rather than as context.

Our waking ego thinks he perceives everything that appears to be taking place, and attributes to himself the independent position of spectator, but he too is merely a part of what appears to be happening, of the scenario of daily life, and is neither more nor less real than any other element therein (Wu Wei, 2003, p. 32).

If there is no mention of an “I” in terms of self-referential narrating; if it is not “created” as such, then where is its existence? It cannot be pointed to. Rather than the spectator, the self appears to be part of the spectacle.

The Illusion of Self: Scientific

As we dismantle the self’s illusory existence as an internal, willful, separate “being,” it is important to again reiterate the functional significance of its existence as a psychological complex. Psychologist Bruce Hood states: “The ‘I’ and the ‘me’ are actually ever-changing narratives generated by our brain to provide a coherent framework to organize the output of all the factors that contribute to our thoughts and behaviors” (Harris, 2012). The “I” point of view connects our experiences together so that we can behave in biologically/socially advantageous ways, as described in detail earlier in this paper. One’s “experience” of anything informs one’s ability to relate to that thing and is continuously at the mercy of environmental factors both internally and externally (Ralston, 2010, p. 482–483). Thus, the “I” itself is an integral aspect of the environment it finds itself in. If this is correct, the “I” would appear to be an aspect of changing factors, rather than the so-called “changer” itself. Researchers in cognitive science confirm this:

In sum, we propose that consciousness (personal awareness) is a product of antecedent brain processes and has no functional role in itself for influencing

subsequent brain states. As such, lacking an executive function, we consider the experience of consciousness as epiphenomenal. We accept that when we refer to, and talk about, personal awareness, this reference is not caused by personal awareness, but is part of the narrative generated directly by ongoing neural processes (Halligan, et al., 2017).

Thus, “the self of everyday cognition is largely an abstraction” (Panksepp, 2012).

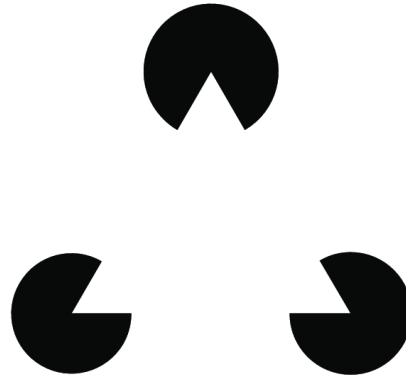
What we perceive to be the conscious self can be reduced to material processes in the brain; a collection of fleeting experiences without a core self that binds them together. This statement is validated by modern neuro-philosophers such as Patricia Churchland, Daniel Dennett, and Keith Frankish (Azarian, 2023). All of these cognitive systems function autonomously and without a purported “will.” Neurologist, Dr. Marcus Raichle, recently named this particular mode of functioning The Default Mode Network; a group of brain regions involved in memory and adaptive mental models. Neuroscientists point to this region being most active when engaged in internal thought or contemplation (Crawford, 2022). A number of peer-reviewed studies have linked this network to the sense of self (Azarian, 2023). This is preliminary structural evidence to support Julian Jaynes’ (1976) approach to consciousness as inner dialogue, with the “perceiver” being created from content.

Cognitive scientist Douglas Hofstadter, also provides support for the argument that the self emerges in relation to a system of cognitive processes. Our ability to model the world and ourselves creates a “self-referential feedback loop whereby cognition reflects upon itself” (Azarian, 2023). This gives the illusion of control, laying the groundwork for consciousness and a sense of self.

Let us take a look at a few cognitive experiments that provide additional support for the illusory nature of subjectivity. Swedish researchers Valeria Petkova and Henrik Ehrsson set up an experiment in 2008 where a participant's real hand is concealed and stroked at the same time that a visible rubber hand in front of them is also stroked. It was shown that the brain will trick a participant into thinking that the rubber hand is actually their own. This provided significant evidence that the personal experience of body "ownership" can be easily distorted (Ehrsson, et al., 2008).

Notable research by scientist Benjamin Libet in the 1980s showed that the brain registers decisions before they are consciously accounted for. In Libet's experiments, a participant would perform a simple task and note the moment they were aware of the decision to move. EEG electrodes attached to their head monitored brain activity. Libet found consistent results showing brain activity at least a half second before the participant was aware of a decision (Guggisberg, 2013). Interestingly enough, Libet's experiments have since been repeated using functional magnetic resonance imaging and it has been shown that a person's decision can be predicted as much as 6-10 seconds before their conscious awareness of it (Bregadze, 2023). These findings support social psychologist Daniel Wegner's (2003) assertion that conscious will is in fact an illusion. It is created by the brain, and we take credit for actions after the fact.

The brain is known to fill in the gaps of experience to create mental cohesion. For example, when you look at the Kanizsa triangle (Figure 2), you will see an invisible triangle, the outlines of which are only loosely defined by the minimal surrounding context. Our brains generate the neural activity as if the shape was actually there, "hallucinating" the experience (Harris, 2012).

Figure 2

As we can see from these experiments, conclusions are made from personal experience. Philosopher John Searle points out in his book, *The Mystery of Consciousness*, that many psychologists and neuroscientists “believe that certain features of consciousness, like subjectivity, qualia, and intentionality, will never submit to scientific scrutiny” (Schooler, 2012, p. 70). Based upon the preceding review of literature, these are the principal features of consciousness, and yet cannot be objectively studied as such. Neuroscientific research can only bring us so far since we can only infer the activity of consciousness through correlation. Standardized scientific inquiry is insufficient to explore the experience of consciousness and self, since mind is not materially objective or directly quantifiable. This impasse brings us to the research study portion of this paper, as subjective inquiry and personal observance of the nature of mind is the most direct way to approach the actual experience of self.

CHAPTER 3

RESEARCH METHODS

Research Approach

In affirming that consciousness, ego, and self are all subjective experiences, I am undertaking a heuristic research approach, using various forms of meditation to investigate these appearances experientially. The heuristic investigation will be divided into phenomenological and ontological approaches, based upon a necessarily conceptual attempt to break down “what is.”

Regarding experience, we infer that there is the “happening” of the content of experience, and the knowing or the “isness” of that content. The happening of the content is in the realm of phenomenology and the existence of the content is in the realm of ontology; the actual beingness. This seemingly dual nature of existence relates to the ancient Buddhist Heart Sutra text:

Form is emptiness and the very emptiness is form; emptiness does not differ from form, form does not differ from emptiness, whatever is emptiness, that is form, the same is true of feelings, perceptions, impulses, and consciousness (Conze, 1967).

This points to the fundamental emptiness of all phenomena, and essentially its nondual nature despite its dual appearance. This will be explored in the study, as the existence of consciousness appears to be inherently dual (self/other). Is this duality a fact of reality, or is it illusory?

The phenomenological portion of the study will address the contents of experience in terms of sensory and thought forms. The tools of mindfulness meditation and self-inquiry will be utilized. Mindfulness meditation has deep roots within Eastern religious practice and uses attention to focus on experiences within the present moment:

It typically involves directing your awareness to your breath, your thoughts, the physical sensations in your body and the feelings you are experiencing. The acceptance piece involves observing those feelings and sensations without judgment. Instead of responding or reacting to those thoughts or feelings, you aim to note them and let them go (Creswell, 2019).

Mindfulness informs and aids the secondary process of self-inquiry, which uses directed questioning (*who am I?*) to hone-in on the presence of the questioner:

This practice of self-attention or awareness of the ‘I’-thought is a gentle technique which bypasses the usual repressive methods of controlling the mind. It is not an exercise in concentration, nor does it aim at suppressing thoughts; it merely invokes awareness of the source from which the mind springs. The method and goal of self-enquiry is to abide in the source of the mind and to be aware of what one really is by withdrawing attention and interest from what one is not (Godman, 1985, p. 56).

Based on a great deal of previous personal experience with both of these forms of meditation, I have come to see that mindfulness is very useful in learning to focus attention, and self-inquiry is very valuable for being able to abstractly separate one’s “beingness” from the content of experience. However, both forms eventually reach an

apparent dead end because the subject/object relational stance is continuously maintained within these methods. This brings us to the second portion of the study which is ontological.

Within the final portion of the methodology, the contents and concepts of the mind are disregarded in favor of investigating pure beingness. The ontological approach uses the tool of bare attention or direct awareness. However, it is not quite a tool because it already and always *is* without any requirement of doing anything. This peripheral awareness is always present whether one knows it or not (Martin, 2019). It is the ground of being itself and leaves room for no “other.” It is unlike the more directed approach of mindfulness, because while useful, mindfulness can create a very subtle observing self that solidifies distinction and “twoness.” The opposing challenge that the ontological approach presents is that “abiding as the source of mind” inherently lacks the relational twoness, and thus begs the question as to whether experience can be *known* in any way. This will be attentively explored.

To summarize the research approach, the personal meditative exploration to study the arising of the sense of self will be twofold. The first portion will involve actively investigating from a positional perspective (phenomenological), while the second portion will be passively resting as “what is” (ontological). The experiences within these approaches will be evaluated and compared to the best of my ability, in the light of the previously examined literature on consciousness and the self.

Research Design

Personal, subjective data will be collected from sixteen years of multifaceted meditation training, including the insight gained from those experiences. This exploration will also include current practice directed toward specified self-inquiry in addition to bare attention. Assessed categories will be presented as experiential realizations from life events and understanding gained from meditative tools. The experiential realizations will address the necessity of ego as a psychological complex, and the ego as but a singular facet of the psyche. The understanding gained from meditative tools will address content in relation to a subject (mindfulness), shifting attention from objects to subject (self-inquiry), and pervasive non-localized awareness lacking directed focus (bare attention).

Research Subjects

The singular subject is myself, Kelly Drew Foster. I am a 36-year-old female residing in Northern California. I have practiced meditation for sixteen years in various contexts, both formally and informally. I have extensive experience particularly with Vipassana meditation, which is a type of mindfulness meditation that encourages heightened focus and concentration on the physical body.

Instrumentation and Data Collection

The meditative practices used within this study have all typically been undertaken in quiet environments with comfortable seating and eyes closed. For the bare attention practice, I often used a light-blocking eye mask and earplugs for further sensory deprivation. Data collection procedures involve reference to documented experiences from journaling and memory.

CHAPTER 4

RESULTS

Summary

Within this chapter, the comparative insights on the arising of the self, gained from the meditative tools of mindfulness meditation, pointed self-inquiry, and bare attention, will be explored in detail.

Hypothesis/Research Questions

The hypothesis for this study is that the subjective, separate “self” that appears to be the center of conscious awareness, is an illusion. In this context, the existence of an illusion is viewed as having no reality outside the experience of itself. Is the “self” an illusion in this sense? Is it permanent and unchanging, or does it come and go? If it does appear to be an illusion, what are the repercussions/implications of identifying with an illusion?

Results

The following preliminary “results” stem from past personal realizations that serve as background for the more formalized meditative portion of the study. Fifteen years ago, in my early 20s, I found myself in a very psychological stressful time as I was struggling to “find myself;” to understand who I was in the world and what I wanted out of life. I adapted to a number of different social groups in college as a way to try on various aspects of my personality and see how they were received by peers. As a creative individual I was very introverted and had to make a great deal of effort to “fit in” socially.

My ego structure was at a developmental pinnacle, and yet, at the same time, I became highly interested in Buddhism and the spiritualized notions that life was suffering and the self I perceived as separate did not exist independently. This led to an extreme internal conflict in the sense that I was instinctively trying to become someone, while conceptually adopting that belief that I was no one.

The ordeal led to severe depression as I began to become a “someone” who completely rejected the personality, character traits, thoughts, beliefs, nuances, and intuition of my “someoneness.” In a constant state of confusion and uncertainty about what was happening, I sought out a spiritual community in hopes of finding guidance. After college I moved to the Tibetan Buddhist Nyingma Institute in Berkeley, California to complete a live-in work/study program. A year and a half of meditation, chanting, spiritual study, and retreats passed, but rather than finding the idealized no-self spiritual fulfillment that I was purposefully seeking, I found the self-central social fulfillment that I was unconsciously, desperately needing. By living with a wonderful, like-minded group of people and forming healthy relationships, my ego was able to find solid footing. A much greater sense of peace and ease came through the back door in a sense, by finding personal confidence to exist in the world in a natural, intrinsic way.

Nondual author Wei Wu Wei (2003) explains that, “the ego belongs to the so-called relative reality. It may be masked by the fictitious ‘me,’ but itself is a functional necessity” (p. 39). The key words here are “functional necessity,” as it became absolutely clear to me that a repression or rejection of basic ego operation was highly dangerous for a developing mind. Carl Jung also supported this notion, emphasizing that the first half of life should be devoted to forming a healthy ego in relation to others, in

regards to becoming a stable individual. The second half of life is when the positional letting go can take place (Jung, 1973).

Jungian analyst Edward Edinger (1984) echoed the importance of ego. He viewed it as a vessel for “divine conflict;” a crucible for the development of consciousness and meaning that could both hold and meditate between the opposing facets of human experience (p. 22). The paradoxical nature of the psyche becomes more and more apparent through the ego’s continual, reflexive practice of mediation. Through identification with the ego explicitly, suffering becomes very apparent amidst this push and pull of opposites. In the Wei Wu Wei quote above regarding the “fictitious me” that masks the ego, it is this portion that must be teased apart from the conventional functional complex of the ego. “The task of the suffering ego becomes the objectification of its subjectivity” (Edinger, 2018, p. 115). This is exactly what I later found to be experientially true.

Post-college and into my early 30s, after having developed a stable sense of self and confidence in my own abilities, I began to question the nature of this self once again. However, with a healthy persona intact, this time the questioning happened through a lens of greater equanimity. Through continued meditation practice, and general life experience, I began to observe that the back-and-forth mediating of my ego was happening of its own accord, despite its seemingly willful, highly personal nature. Rational, purposeful, decision-oriented thoughts appeared in much the same way as the sudden bombardment of primitive fantasies, or highly moral principles. “The experience of the supporting aspect of the archetypal psyche is most likely to occur when the ego has

exhausted its own resources and is aware of its essential impotence by itself” (Edinger, 1972, p. 50).

There appeared to be something analogous to a natural balancing act happening on a continuous spectrum. The ego was an integral part of something much larger that was not always within the view of consciousness. Wei Wu Wei (2004) explains that the I-notion, which appears to have intention, is but a reflex. He sees human beings as “puppets reacting to impulses engendered by psychic conditions over which they have no control” (p. 67).

In realizing that “I” was not intentionally creating any of the thoughts that appeared in my mind, the subjectivity and apparent control of my very own “I-ness” began to seem highly questionable. This led me into a deep exploration of Advaita Vedanta and the proposed nondual nature of reality. Consequently, many years of personal insight-oriented results through research, meditation, and self-inquiry now form the backbone of this study.

This next portion of the results section addresses more direct inferences from the meditative tools of mindfulness meditation, pointed self-inquiry, and bare attention. My personal practice of mindfulness meditation within many varied forms over the last sixteen years has shown clear results in terms of increased consciousness. Placing attention on the contents of experience, whether through the senses, or within thoughts, obviously creates more “knowing” of content that may have previously been unknown. When something becomes an object within one’s awareness, one ceases to identify with it (Masters, 2010, p. 29). Rather than existing *as* it, one is aware *of* it. Rather than being completely overtaken and consumed by an emotion such as anger, one can see the anger

as it is, and thus create space between the experience and experiencer. In this sense, mindfulness is initially undertaken as a practice in duality in order to create more consciousness around what is happening. As practice evolves, there is less *being* of content, and more *seeing* of content.

Personally, I found that the more content came to be *known*, the more a new, more subtle layer of content arose regarding the underlying meaning and intention of the content. After considerable struggle to see that this too is also content within the mind, attention began to naturally move more toward the process itself.

Mindfulness meditation differs from psychoanalytic inquiry in that the contents of consciousness – the specific representations of self and other and their configurations – are not attended to or analyzed. Instead, by direct attention to the process whereby all manifestations of self arise and pass away, are constructed and deconstructed, moment by moment, irrespective of content, mindfulness leads to insight into the nature of all representations of self and reality as constructions only, and as ungraspable in any real or definitive sense (Engler, 2006, p. 68).

When everything began to be seen as the content of experience, including the very interpretations and representations of myself, there was a natural movement to question the inference of the questioner. Content always seemed to appear in relation to a subjective “I,” but was there really an “I” that was choosing, deciding, or at the very least, *knowing* experience? Was there really, in fact, an experiencer of experience?

This line of questioning leads to the pointed self-inquiry results within the study. Attention shifted from the objects of body/mind to the apparent subject, “I.” In

attempting to “abide as awareness” (as many modern nondual spiritual teachers put it), I ultimately found myself identifying with a new and subtle facet of ego. As the “witness” of whatever was taking place, I began feeling removed from experience. It became a subtle, dangerously spiritualized version of dissociation in the sense of becoming disconnected and removed from experience. I continued to question this apparent “witnesser” from several angles.

Is there an “I” that is actually being affected by circumstances and emotions? Psychotherapist Mark Epstein (2013) points out that, “in a period of intensive meditation one sees many embarrassing things about oneself, but if one looks intently enough, one finds no one (no thinker) to be embarrassed by it all” (p. 116). Anything that appeared always seemed to be in *relation* to the apparent one that was being affected. However, all that ever appeared was the content-effects themselves, such as the thought, “I am sad,” or a physical pain discomfort. The “I” that claimed to be bothered only appeared as another thought.

This directly relates to nondual spiritual author Wei Wu Wei’s (2004b) claim that, “‘I’ am not conscious of anything, never. ‘Consciousness’ as such is all that I am.” It became clear that consciousness, or the dual appearance of subject and object in order for something to be “known,” was the extent of the “I” appearance. The claim of knower or witness only appeared as thoughts within the dual nature of language. The conceptual designation of subject could not point to any-*thing* in actual reality, because anything conceived of was obviously only another object.

The knowing, the seeing, and the introspecting all appear only as an analogy (Jaynes, 1976, p. 450). In this way, it was seen that the very act of cognizing or knowing

was also a play of language. If there was not an actual knower, how could there be knowing in regards to an action being performed? There was only what was known. Wei Wu Wei (2003) goes on to say, “We observe that we can often do as we will, but we have no reason to suppose that we can influence that will. Presumably that will itself is subject to determination, the mechanism of which we are unable to perceive (p. 56).

Inquiring into the very root of decision-making demonstrated this – decisions appeared, confusion appeared, indecisiveness appeared – but all without a “doer” per se. Nondual author Joan Tollifson (2017) supports this in saying, “the apparently separate self, if investigated closely, is simply ever-changing thoughts, sensations, memories, mental images and stories appearing in consciousness. It cannot actually be found as any kind of substantial or persisting entity.” If that which I believe myself to be truly cannot be found as a *thing*, where does that leave us?

This is where the practice of non-practice comes into play. Bare attention, or non-localized awareness is without a directed, controlled focus. It simply is what it is. It differs from consciousness in the sense that any form of “knowing” appears *within* and *as* this awareness. It became clear that consciousness and any form of the arising of self cannot exist without this ground of being, or *isness*. Its very nature *is* this. Psychotherapist John Welwood (2002) explains that pure awareness is never confined or disrupted by any state of consciousness. It cannot be grasped as an object or a thing. It is almost too much to even call it awareness because it is not awareness *of* something, as the English language presumes. It is just *this*, and always this, as it is.

“I,” or the sense of self as subtly angled arising content, vanishes into and as that which is. I refer back to the Buddhist Heart Sutra in that, “form is emptiness and the very

emptiness is form” (Conze, 1967). Consciousness, and that which “I” perceive myself to be, is but a fleeting appearance within what *is* and what therefore cannot be *known* as such. We are left with a paradox because all understanding, and thus all “results” from this study can only be conveyed through consciousness – through language – through a perspective – through knowing – through “I,” Since this “I” has been exhibited to be wholly made up of that which is, it has no position *outside* of what is. Therefore, there is no angle that can be taken.

Knowing that the observed has no existence apart from the observer, knowing that the observer has no existence apart from the observed, divided mind is reunited.
(Wu Wei, 2004b)

CHAPTER 5

SUMMARY, DISCUSSION, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Summary

Within this study, I sought to personally investigate whether or not the subjective, separate “self” that appears to be at the center of conscious awareness, is an illusion. Through previous experience and meditative investigations via mindfulness, self-inquiry, and bare attention, it was ultimately revealed that the “I” has no solid, separate, continuous existence outside of the perceived experience of itself. It appears to be a sporadic thought-based identification that arises out of conscious “knowing.” It was seen that this “I” can be mistaken for the instinctual psychological functioning of the ego complex, as well as the position of the subjective, dissociated perspective of the knower or witnesser. In both cases it is taken to be a “thing,” whether directly or subtly. In a metacognitive sense, thought turns in on itself and either claims ownership, or takes a position.

Through self-inquiry into subjectivity, it was seen that this positioning and claiming of ownership is merely more thought content, rather than an *actual* subjective viewpoint outside of the content of experience. The apparent “I” perspective arises in the just the same way as sensations, coming and going from an imperceptible source. Even the indication of a source is deceiving because it too is a concept arising in thought. All we are left with is the appearance of what is. All conscious capability to know arises within and as this, so it cannot in any sense step back from all that is to be able to see and know it.

Once more I will refer to Figure 1 to show the visual interpretations of this study. Perception, cognition, consciousness, and “I,” all metaphorically evolve “inwards.” Each inner field arises from the field of larger context, and all ultimately exist in and as the very ground of being itself. The previously reviewed literature supports the notion that the solidly colored fields of perception, cognition, and consciousness all have perceivable qualities (from the perspective of consciousness “knowing”). Perception arises through the five senses, cognition arises through the mind/psyche (thoughts), and consciousness arises through the thought-based orientation of the ego. The “I,” as the presumed knower, thinker, feeler, and doer is illusory, as it is a mere inference. This is why it remains white, which is the same as the background of awareness. Within the study it was seen that nothing ever appears to arise from some-*thing* that acts with intention. Intention only ever arises in thought conception, as does all understanding.

It feels a bit ironic that in essence, this study has no *real* subjective angle, so it does not leave anything to hold on to. In seeing that the self does not and cannot exist outside the seeing of it, we are brought full circle back to where we started as children and as ancient humans within the oneness of *participation mystique*, much like the ancient symbol of the ouroboros swallowing its own tail. However, in acquiring consciousness, subject can now be distinguished from object; this from that; I from you. And yet the world only *appears* to become known because the knowing is made of unknowing. All appearances are contained within the wholeness and infinity of what is, including the notion of “I.” My perceived perspective is a wave within the ocean. The arising waves of “I” appear with individualized characteristics, willfulness, and endless nuance, but never exist apart from the ocean of what is.

Discussion

While the “wholeness” of what is cannot actually be approached or abstracted, we can still attempt to conceptually approach the individual identification with an isolated perspective, and how this is illusory. Psychotherapist Charles Martin (2019) phrases it in terms of: “In short, the ‘experience’ of the nondual is the ‘experience’ of the collapse of the subject-object dichotomy. In other words, awareness just is. There is not someone being aware of something. Just this.” I would argue that the collapse of subjective identification is not an *experience* as we have come to define the term, and thus it is quite misleading to use that word. As Martin says, it is “just this.” How can the subject-object dichotomy collapse if it is *already* not happening? If something is as it is, it essentially becomes unknown (Ralston, 2010, p. 465). By definition, all that *is*, is objective. Therefore, even the hyper-knowing that arises with the metacognitive “I” claiming to do this or that, is not an experience as such because the claims are thought-objects. There is no experience without an experiencer, and if the experiencer is an integral part of the experience, there can only be what is.

From a psychologically evolutionary perspective, this can be conceptualized as a circular path. Jungian analyst Edward Edinger (1972) posits that the ultimate goal of human psychological development is to recover the lost state of wholeness, but on a level of conscious realization (p. 290). He explains how transpersonal life energy uses human consciousness (a product of itself) as an instrument to realize itself (p. 104). As Carl Jung clarifies, each of us are nature’s attempt at a new synthesis. It is an instinctual process that unfolds in its own way, without regard for the illusory sense of self that claims to be making it happen. If the right combination of factors comes together, then the flower will

bloom. In no way can it be willfully forced, just like the act of falling asleep each night. Jung acknowledges that the course of human individuation is dialectical and relational until the ego is confronted with this emptiness of the center (Edinger, 2018, p. 23). Without conceptual ownership of the process, ego is no longer assumed to be the central reference point of cognition.

This eventual “allowance” for what is, on the part of nature, also addresses the human suffering portion of the illusory “I” identification. Psychotherapist and spiritual teacher John Prendergast (2003) thoughtfully expounds:

When we do not separate ourselves from the mystery of our own essential awake being, or separate ourselves from experiencing the truth of the moment as it is – the felt sense of the body of being – we do not suffer. Physical bodies may experience pain; thinking minds may be confused; emotions may present themselves as intensely positive or negative; but we are not suffering. We are living from the truth of our wholeness, being who/what we truly are, and this is never divided, never in conflict, even when conflict is being played out (p. 168).

Perhaps to put it more bluntly, and yet paradoxically, even when suffering is playing out, there is *no one* to be suffering. Suffering exists as an integral part of the play of life.

Prendergast goes on to say:

When we have realized from our own direct, experiential knowing that there is no one and no thing separate from the vast Mystery that unfolds itself seamlessly as a whole every moment, and that we are That, we no longer imagine or identify with an “I” who is separate (p. 168–169).

In regards to what has been evaluated through the literature, and experienced through the personal research study, the separate “I” is not a thing that can be apprehended in any way, shape, or form. All action verbs that we credit the “I” with are merely a play of language. Thus, everything is already unfolding interdependently, and of its own accord, without a doer, whether or not this comes to be seen as such.

Recommendations

The sense of self has been investigated through meditative methods by many individuals in the past. However, the insight gained from such investigations cannot, in actuality, be imparted by way of intellectual knowledge. One must explore experiential reality for oneself in order for this study to have any real weight. At the same time, I have found it very useful to study the evidential and philosophical backing within the fields of psychology, neuroscience, history, and spirituality. Background knowledge in the development and evolution of the psyche throughout human history is very useful for providing perspective and context. I think much more integrative research can be taken on with regard to how these fields overlap and intersect within the understanding of the human mind and subjective experience.

I also think that for the sake of clarity, it is vital that researchers, authors, and spiritual teachers recognize the importance of defining the ways in which they are using the terms consciousness, awareness, and self. There is such an overwhelming amount of confusion and misunderstanding as a result of utilizing these terms incredibly differently, and often interchangeably. The dynamics of language play a very considerable part in our understanding of these concepts, so it is of the utmost importance to be clear about what

exactly one is referring to when speaking within the fields of consciousness studies and transpersonal psychology.

I would also like to see more research on the repercussions of human identification with self. The development of consciousness has immense benefits for personal awareness and interpersonal relations. However, I think it is important to remember that, based on the previously analyzed research, it is a mental capacity that developed out of adaptational needs for social structure. It is a *tool* of the mind rather than what we actually *are*. Consciousness, or knowing, is only the end-all-be-all in relation to itself; just as how light appears to be ubiquitous from a flashlight's perspective.

Modern Western society places a great deal of importance on knowledge and this spotlight of knowing. With the ceaseless push of technology and direct access to all forms of information, I think that a great majority of us often find ourselves in metacognitive binds. We are constantly rethinking our choices and seeking more – better – faster, on all levels. Language and conceptual, metaphorical reality is now expanding at a rate that is much more rapid than physical reality. It is clear that this is causing a great deal of stress and anxiety in modern humans. Historically, in the development of language, words were created in direct reference to something within our experience. Today, concepts have become so complex and layered, many of which have no relation to our day-to-day experience with external reality. In a sense, we are living more and more within a cerebral hallucination without regard for the sans-self beingness that we actually *are*.

As I have come to conclude within this paper, the paradoxical challenge is that *knowing* cannot access *being*. Therefore, there comes a point when the activity of

consciousness reaches its limits. As the dynamics of human consciousness continue to evolve on a larger scale, I am really interested to see the ways in which we are forced to address the imbalance between cerebral knowing and actual being. As it becomes more challenging to exist as a separate, theoretical self in a world of abstract ideas, I believe that alternative modes of exploring the nature of self will naturally begin to arise. At a certain point, as a result of prolonged suffering, I think we will be instinctively urged to focus more on the unfocused and nonconceptual – on the raw, felt, fleeting, lived experience of being a human.

Spiritual psychotherapist John Prendergast (2003) declares, “we need a more comprehensive view that recognizes the nonduality of transcendent and immanent, absolute and relative, emptiness and form” (p. 150). I believe this calls for integration and wholeness by way of multiplicity and diversity. If we consciously come to know the means by which ourselves take shape, and the incredibly individualized and variable ways that they instinctually appear to exist in the world, then perhaps the ground can be prepared for a naturally evolved recognition of the underlying non-doership within that knowing. With our heightened conscious capacity to identify, define, compare, and relate, perhaps we will evolve to “see” that all of our efforting is somehow effortless... that feelings happen without a feeler, thoughts without a thinker, knowing without a knower... and that the singularity of life has and always will flow on of its own accord.

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